

Accidentals

Accidentals are notes that are sharp or flat outside a key signature. Depending on the key signature, accidentals may be written as sharps, flats, naturals, double sharps, or double flats.

SEE ALSO

◀ 48–51 Sharps and flats

◀ 64–67 Keys

Modulation 74–75 ▶

Harmony 118–119 ▶

Using accidentals

If a sharp, flat, or natural does not belong to the music's key signature, it is an accidental, and the symbol for the accidental must be written before the note on the staff. Double sharps and double flats are always accidentals.

Sharp symbol indicates the accidental C[♯].

Flat symbol indicates the accidental E[♭].

46 ▼ Sharps
The key here is G major. C[♯] is an accidental because it does not belong to the key signature.

47 ▼ Flats
Here the key is F major. E[♭] is an accidental because it does not belong to the key signature.

Canceling accidentals

Accidentals should be canceled if the note that was an accidental earlier returns to being a note that belongs to the key signature within the same measure. This is done by writing a sharp, flat, or natural symbol before the accidental that has been canceled.

Type of accidental	Canceled by the accidental
Sharp	Natural
Flat	Natural
Natural	Sharp or flat
Double sharp	Single sharp
Double flat	Single flat

◁ Canceling accidentals

This table shows which accidentals are used to cancel sharps, flats, naturals, double sharps, and double flats.

◁ Canceling sharps
The key here is A major. The accidental D[♯] is canceled by D[♮]. Flats are also canceled by naturals.

◁ Canceling naturals
Here the key is B[♭] major. The accidental E[♮] is canceled by E[♭]. In keys with sharps, naturals are canceled by sharps.

◁ Canceling double sharps
The key here is D[♯] minor. The accidental C[×] is canceled by C[♯].

◁ Canceling double flats
Here the key here is G[♭] major. The accidental E^{♭♭} is canceled by E[♭].